

Try Hack Me – The Letter – OSINT

Story:

It's just another Monday morning on your mail delivery route when an unusual letter catches your eye. The envelope is battered, riddled with holes as if it's been through a storm. The address is barely legible, and your coworkers at the post office wave it off as a lost cause.

But something about it nags at you.

You carefully open the damp envelope. Inside, you find a faded newspaper clipping and a short handwritten note. The clipping is torn and water-damaged, with key sections missing. The note is personal, clearly not meant for your eyes, but the fragments you can read hint at a story buried in time.

Objective: Use the clues provided in the zip file to uncover the full name and age of the person mentioned in the note.

Questions:

- 1) What is the postal code of the delivery address on the envelope?
- 2) What is the flag? Full name and age of the person mentioned in the note.

Example: THM{Pierre-Henry_Lagaffe_23}

Tools: DeepL, Copilot – for translations

Clues:

1) Letter



2) Newspaper clipping



3) Note

Mon cher Édouard,

Aujourd'hui, en rangeant le grenier chez mes grands-parents, je suis tombée sur cette vieille coupure de journal. Ton arrière-grand-père n'avait même pas l'âge de passer le permis quand il s'est distingué ce jour-là. Le benjamin de l'équipe, et certainement pas le moins courageux.

Il serait si fier de te voir sur l'eau à ton tour.

Avec toute mon affection,
Audette

Key findings:

1) Letter:

- a) The envelope is originally from France (logo La Poste, post stamp, Lettre Verte – type of postal service)
- b) The envelope is damaged by moisture and the address is illegible. The name Edouard and the abbreviation SNSM are visible.

Questions: What is SNSM?

The abbreviation SNSM in this context refers to Société Nationale de Sauvetage en Mer (the National Sea Rescue Society).

2) Handwritten note:

It was in the letter. It is in French language. The message reads:

My dear Édouard,

Today, while I was cleaning out my grandparents' attic, I came across this old newspaper clipping. Your **great-grandfather wasn't even old enough to take his driver's test** when **he distinguished himself that day**. He was the youngest member of the team, but certainly not the least brave.

He would be so proud if he could see you out on the water.

3) Newspaper clipping:

- a) I tried to find the newspaper from which the clipping came. I use web pages of BNF and web of the Gallica project. I found that the newspaper came from 24. Mai 1925.

L'Ouest-Éclair, 24. Mai 1925.



- b) I looked through the articles on the page of the newspaper from which the clipping was taken. There's an article about Amundsen's expedition, the war in Morocco, and a maritime disaster in France. The last one is interesting because the letter contained the abbreviation SNSM (Société de Sauvetage en Mer), and the two might be related.

My initial thought was that the person in question had distinguished themselves in the war in Morocco, but the article contained no specific clues that would lead me further. Therefore, based on the other clues (the address on the envelope), I decided to focus on the article about the maritime disaster.

Using Copilot, I had it extract all the place names, proper nouns, and references to the ages of the people involved from the article, and then translate them into English.

Places mentioned: Pointe de Penmarch – the site where the tragedy occurred (29760); Saint-Pierre-Penmarch – the area where the fishing boats were in distress; Kérity – the home port of one of the rescue boats; Guilvinec – the administrative district from which the administrator de la Manire arrived; Brest – the location from which the report was sent to the newspaper.

Description of the event: 1) Two fishing boats (7 men, 5 men) got into trouble near Saint-Pierre-Penmarch. 2) Two rescue boats (each with a crew of 12 men) set out immediately to help. 3) Upon arrival at the scene, the area was hit by waves that capsized all the boats—both the fishing boats and the rescue boats. 4) Of the 50 men, 26 drowned. 5) One of the rescue boats managed to right itself and save part of the crew.

People involved: boats – Société de Sauvetage Léon-Dufour; Comte-et-Comtesse-Foucher; the rescuers were described as fathers of large families; M. Le Gall, president of the fishing cooperative in Kérity, saw the capsized boats, personally rescued 6 men, and attempted in vain to revive 3; The Administrator of the Guilvinec Navy arrived at the scene and took the necessary measures; the Prefect of Finistère arrived at the scene of the tragedy.

I tried to look up the ZIP codes for the place names I found. And Pointe de Penmarch – ZIP 29760 was the right answer.

Then I need to know names of the crew and find the youngest man. So I need more information about the catastrophe. Fulltext search: tragedy penmarch'h 23. 5. 1925, I find the web La catastrophe du 23 mai 1925 à Penmarch'h. The web includes the names of the victims, all crew members, and the names of the decorated rescuers, along with their ages.

The web: [La catastrophe du 23 mai 1925 à Penmarch'h](#)

In the web site I find that the youngest decorated rescuer was Yves-Marie Gourlaouen, 15 years old.

Flag: THM{Yves-Marie_Gourlaouen_15}

Postal code of the delivery address on the envelope: 29760

